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Derek Smith

Pianist Derek Smith was born in Stratford, England in 1931. A veteran of the RAF, he became a full time musician with the BBC and band leader Johnny Dankworth. He emigrated to the U.S. in 1957 and after a short period of non-music jobs he was able to record with Connie Kay and Percy Heath. Derek went on to tour and record with Benny Goodman, Buddy DeFranco, and Benny Carter, and held down the piano chair in the Tonight Show Band from 1967-1974, moving with the group from New York to Los Angeles. Today he will be found at numerous festivals and jazz cruises and is a member of The Trio with Milt Hinton and Bob Rosengarden

Derek was interviewed by Michael Woods and Monk Rowe on May 29, 1995 aboard a jazz cruise in the Caribbean.

MR: We are here on behalf of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive Project on the Royal Caribbean cruise, and we're talking with Derek Smith, a well traveled piano player who is performing this evening. And we're here to get his thoughts on the state of jazz and his experiences in the jazz world. So welcome.

DS: Thank you.

MR: It's a pleasure to have you here today.

DS: "Well-traveled" — that's not usually used — I'm usually described as a "pianist of ill-repute."

MR: I think that's in the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz* as a matter of fact.

DS: Well traveled. I like that. That's nice.

MR: It's interesting to talk, we have talked with I think one other person who came from England — Jillean Williams actually — and we were getting her take on how jazz was kind of spread from America to other parts, and we wondered if you could tell us how it came to be that you became a jazz musician.

DS: Well, it was disseminated through records of course, and when I was a kid, you couldn't buy American records for some — I'll never understand to this day why — but they weren't allowed. The government after the war distrusted everybody I think and American records were not allowed in. But somehow I got to hear a record by Art Tatum, it's an absolute classic, "Tea for Two." And up until then I'd just been listening to everybody and imitating anybody, any piano player. I mean I didn't know the difference between a classical piano and a jazz piano player. I just tried to play anything, you know. I'd listen all day to the radio and then run in to where the piano was and woodshed all this stuff. And then one day I heard this Art Tatum thing, and it was like suddenly getting

a focus. I felt, you know, if I could play like that, you know. And I spent the last 50 years trying, never succeeded, but—

MR: Did you take classical though?

DS: Yes, of course I did. But you have to understand that the war was still on then and I was the same kind of kid as anybody, I didn't really want to practice, even though I knew I had some talent even then. But luckily, my mother and father managed to send me to some different ladies, local ladies that, the first one taught me to read and play scales which I thank God for that she did that; the next one got me on to the Bach inventions; and the third one got me into early Chopin. And believe me, I was so lucky that these people were there. Because if you can still play some of those Chopin etudes, you are a pretty good piano player. But anyway, I digress. But later on, the American records managed to be in England. They were pirated in. They appeared, even though it was against the law. And of course all those guys with talent or who liked this kind of music managed to get them. And we all managed to hear these records, and so it was an imitative process. And even at the time I left, and I was 25 when I left, it was still the same thing. The records were coming in just in a dribble so you didn't really get the whole spectrum. And at that time I thought well it's pointless me staying around London because it's all kind of imitative and if I really want to test myself I've got to go to New York or one of the centers of jazz. So that's what we did and we never looked back.

MR: Wow. That's a big step.

DS: Well at that age you don't realize how big it is, you know. Now looking back I would never have done that I suppose.

MR: Did you have any connections when you first came here?

DS: Not a soul. No. Luckily my wife and I were getting married and we thought, we'll try. We can always come back.

MW: How did you get started in New York? How did you survive like the first three months?

DS: You really want a story? You can edit all this. First of all, you know I came to New York not knowing a soul, but I found out where the musician's union was, and, you've got to remember that when I was in England they talked about the American musician's union as being so powerful, and a great union, and they'll take care of you. So I went straight down there. And the guy heard my English accent and he said, "you coming here?" I said, "yeah." He said, "you can't join." I said, "what do you mean?" He said, "there's a feud between the two unions" (the English union and the American union). "Over there they won't allow American musicians to join, so you can't join." And he put the thing out in my face. And I said "how will I make a living?" He said, "that's your problem." So, but he did say, "you can come back in six months. If you can prove that you've been in New York for six months then you can join." So I got a job in insurance.

MR: I read that. That you sold insurance.

DS: No, I didn't sell insurance. I showed up every day at an office, and luckily I didn't do too much damage. I didn't ruin the company. But I really had very little aptitude for it. I looked kind of busy and went through the motions. But six months to the day I left and went back to the union, and that's another story. The same guy was there. He said, "you again?" So I said, "yes, and now, you know I really need it." So he says, "well you've got to take an audition." I said, "fine" — you know I'd been practicing. So he says, "go in there" and I had to follow the lady in — there was a lady in there and she was taking the audition on maracas, do you believe this? She was a singer, but she wanted to join the musician's union so she took it on maracas. So they said "next."

MW: Am I correct in saying the singers have to be in the actor's guild?

DS: No, they've got a separate union now, which is, I forget what it is because it doesn't really concern me. But at that time, they had to be in the musician's union. Otherwise they couldn't work. It was very strongly unionized. So anyway, he says, "next." So I go into this room, there's the piano. And he says, "what's that instrument over there?" I said, "what are you talking about?" I says, "a piano." He says, "you're in. Now go upstairs and pay your hundred dollars." I said, "what?" I started roaring. He says, "that's very nice, now go upstairs."

MR: Kind of makes you wonder about the level of musicianship that they might have in the unions.

DS: I mean I'm all for auditions, but they should be serious.

MR: Yeah, if you're going to do it.

MW: And they made you wait six months for that.

DS: Well that was a thing to protect — it's unionism at its worst. I think it was there to protect the jobs of people who were there. They didn't want too many new people coming in and taking their jobs away. Not that I was about to take anybody's job, but I just wanted to be a part of the scene.

MW: Who did you start working with?

DS: Oh, well. All right. That's another story. This is, I've been in the country two weeks, no a week, and my wife and I, we'd run out of money because we'd stayed in a hotel in New York and we said well we can't live here, it's too much money. So we found an apartment in Brooklyn. And I looked in the local paper, and I saw there was a concert by the Modern Jazz Quartet at Brooklyn Academy of Music. So I said, I've got to try, I love those guys. You know I'd managed to hear it at some time. And so I got there very early. And there was John Lewis, you know, the leader, and he's putting programs on every seat. You know John took care of everything. He wrote the music, he made the guys rehearse, and he put the programs — he did everything. And I don't know why, I'm

usually a kind of reserved guy, but I started getting into a conversation. And he said, "oh I know you." I said, "how could you possibly know me?" He said, "well I subscribe to this English periodical it's called 'The Gramophone' and they review jazz records. And you made a record in England and I have it." I said, "what!" And I couldn't believe it. He said, "by the way, what are you doing tomorrow night?" And believe me, I don't make up these stories, it's stranger than fiction. I said, "what do you mean, I'm doing nothing." He said, "please be at Atlantic Recording Studios and we'll record something." So I'd been there two weeks and I made my first record. And it was with Percy Heath and Connie Kay — not a bad rhythm section. But of course I was so damn nervous that, you know. I've got the record at home it's not really very good.

MR: Well what was the role with the, I mean, you were both piano players so what was he having—

DS: He was making, it came out, the album was called "Jazz Piano International." So he got me and I was representing England, and he got a French pianist by the name of René Urtreger, and we all played like four tracks. And Dick Katz was there who was the American piano player. And that's how the album came out.

MR: You know there's been so many stories about these kinds of things where people, Al Grey who happened to be a club when the Basie band was there and their trombone player was sick and the guy said, "get your horn" and he ran, and it's just little amazing coincidences that helped people.

DS: Well I mean those things work. And I mean that's, as time goes by, now I'm starting to get a footing, and people say, hey, the kid can play, he speaks kind of weird but he can play, so we'll hire him. And now, that's how I got into the studio business. You know what I mean by the studio — playing jingles and record dates and things like that. There was a big band jingle going on, I forget what it was, for what product. But Hank Jones was supposed to be there and for some reason Hank was sick or something and didn't tell them and he didn't show up. And there was I downstairs in the bar just hanging out, and they said, "oh the kid's down there, get that English kid." And I came in, and I was full of it, and I played my ass off, and they said "okay, the kid's fine." And I never looked back. I got in on Hank's coattail.

MR: That's where that reading too, comes in important, because you can't just walk into a studio.

DS: Well that's where your background comes. I mean if you've gone to the academy — there's no shortcut to reading, you just do it, you just do it. And there's no shortcut. But the point is when you're at that stage, when everything is new, read anything. I always tell kids to do that. Read anything. It doesn't matter what it is. Read saxophone parts. Read anything. Just so that it becomes second nature to you. It's like breathing.

MW: They have a saying at some of the bigger music schools like North Texas State, they say you've got to be able to read fly crap.

DS: Yeah.

MW: The reason why I say that because you know a lot of jazz manuscripts are just scribbled or in pencil, and the stuff is faded and you're reading it in a night club where there's barely any light and there's smoke all in your eyes, you know. So you've got to be able to read anything.

DS: Yeah. I remember being down there. Well now I'm a kind of a -- I'm a veteran. I'm a seasoned veteran, you know, so now they hire me at North Texas State to come down and lecture the kids. Because there, the senior class, they're all 22. They play wonderfully because they've got no experience in the outside world at all. So first of all, I say this wonderful music you've been playing, forget that. This is the real world when you get out there. And you've got to know some songs. And so I'm telling them a lot of songs that you should know. And don't come in dressed the way you're dressed because you'll never get hired again. But that's a good school. And the youngsters there are wonderful.

MW: Have you had occasion to play with the Basie band?

DS: Look, the only time I played with the Basie band, and that's cheating really, I was accompanying Sammy Cahn who was a songwriter of some repute, and Sam would do an act and get a lot of money for playing this act in various parts of the country. So one day Sam called and he'd say, "oh we've got this gig in Chicago." So I says, "fine." He says, "it's with the Basie band." I said, "what?" He hung up the phone. So we had some arrangements, and I just put them out, and I had to get Count off the piano, raise the piano seat because he had it very low, and we went over it. It was the Basie band, and we played all this stuff for Sam. He wasn't a very good singer but he wrote all these songs and so people had to take him seriously. So that was the time with the Basie band. But of course all the side men have been my friends for years, because they like Frank Foster and Frank Wess — we were all in the studios together playing all these dog food commercials for years.

MR: Most of those guys that did that, were they, that was after they had had the Basie experience, the big band road thing.

DS: Right.

MR: And they decided they wanted to stay in one place for a little while?

DS: Yes. Exactly. And that's what they did. And at that time you have to realize there was so much work for musicians, and especially if you came out of a big band background. Because most of the music was kind of jazz influenced. And there was always big budgets for commercials and they wanted the band to sound right. And so all these guys were coming off the bands and moving straight into this highly paid studio work. And,

but then of course nothing stays the same forever, and the studio work disappears now, because, well many different reasons. (a) we all got older; (b) technology put us out of work because they can do things with synthesizers where they don't need so many live musicians anymore. And so then I read that Frank Foster is back on the road now leading the band.

MR: Yeah. We had a nice interview with him a couple of months ago with Bill Hughes. Tell us about working with Benny Goodman.

DS: Well, what do you want to know? It's hard to say. I mean without a doubt, Benny was the finest jazz clarinetist — this is all subjective opinion, certainly my opinion — I've never heard of anybody that played as well as he did that thrilled me as well. But, given all that, which is a big given, he was a very difficult guy to get along with. None of us really knew why. Either he heard — they say that symphony conductors hear what they want to hear of a piece a fraction of a second before the orchestra plays it, and then if the orchestra doesn't play it exactly the way they hear it in their heads, then they get upset. And I think it was something like that with Benny. He heard exactly what he thought it was going to be. And then if the band, if it wasn't exactly the same, he'd get upset and he would start pointing at people. But anyway, it all doesn't matter. Benny's been dead some years now, and all the music, there's so many records of it and it will live forever. It's wonderful music. But the first time I went with him, it was in 1962. I hadn't been in the country that long. And I needed the job, simply to be associated with somebody of that stature. So my friend, he's dead now, the drummer Mousey Alexander, a good friend of mine, he said, "I'll get you on with Benny." So I made all the rehearsals and read the "Stealing Apples" — you know the thing, the lovely — just kept my nose clean and didn't say anything. But then, the night, we were going to go to South America the next day, that was the tour. And so 7:30 the night before we were supposed to go, the manager called me up. He said, "listen, listen carefully." He said, "Benny's going to call in five minutes and he's going to fire you." I said, "what! What have I done! I haven't said anything, I haven't done anything bad." He said, no, but he's going to fire you. But here's what you say. You say well it's all right, Benny, you can fire me, but for the period of three weeks that we're going to be away I've turned down a lot of work, so I feel that you've got to pay me the money that you promised me. And he said, "then he'll hire you again." Five minutes later the phone rings. He says "well, look Pops, it's not working out. You'd better forget it." So I said, "well okay, Mista..mista..mista Go..go..go..go..Goodman," I said, "okay, I understand, but I've turned down all this wo..wo..wo..wo..work, and I feel you sh..sh..should pay me for it." And he says, "okay, you'd better come with us." And I mean that's exactly how it happened.

MR: Wow.

DS: But then, years later, you know I was getting successful then, I was in the NBC band with Doc Severinsen and then, as soon as I finished "The Tonight Show" at seven I'd run upstairs and play with Benny Goodman at the Rainbow Grill, it was all in the same building. I was working like night and day. And I got very close to Benny then, and that was an equal mistake. He would call me up and say, "well what do you think of so-and-so, what do you think of so-and-so," before they hired them. And then the ax fell, as it does with everybody. I think it's 1973 or something. I was still on staff at NBC doing "The Tonight Show" every day, and Benny called and said, "hey look, Pops, we're going down to Australia. It's a great trip, and you really ought to come." I said, "well I'll try and get out of NBC." And so I did and I got my wife's mother and father to come in from England to look after the kids, and we made all this—and we went to Australia. And there we played the first rehearsal and Benny started looking at me funny. He's looking over the clarinet at me. I said what's going on? And that's "the ray." And everybody got it, it doesn't matter who you were. Everybody got it. And I looked at him, and we exchanged a few choice words, and I finished out the tune and never saw him again. But it still doesn't detract, he was the greatest jazz clarinet player. I never understood him as a man but he sure could play.

MR: Tell us a little more about working on the Tonight Show band.

DS: Well it was a great experience. There again, as embarrassing moments — so I got the job, and that's right Skitch Henderson had been the leader, but then there was some trouble there and he left, and Doc Severinsen, my good friend and a great trumpet player, and I was used to working with him in those days in the studios doing something. And he said, "Well I'm the band leader now," you know, "I'd like you to do the job." I said fine. So I show up. And you know you rehearse the music as much as you can, just once through, and then you sit there and the show goes on for an hour and a half and you play what you have to play. But then they come back after the commercial, and a couple of stage hands come up, take the piano away from me, put it right out in the center of the stage. Then he said, "get up." I said, "What do you mean?" They take the piano seat and put it out there. So the camera comes back, and it's just on me, in the center of the stage. The band's over there. And this big fat comic comes out. [Jack E.] Leonard. Oh, he was very big at the time, it was kind of before Don Rickles, his whole act was to insult people. And very funny.

MR: And you didn't know this was coming?

DS: No, no, I didn't know this was coming. I didn't know this from a hole in the wall. But he comes out there and proceeds to do like ten minutes on me. And I'm sitting there. And it's my first day on the job. And I'm steaming. But it all worked out. Everybody had a good laugh at that. The band was killing themselves with laughter. But we had like many

experiences. It was great as a pianist, I mean once a wonderful lady, an opera singer, Marilyn Horne came on. And you know, so we had a rehearsal, a very fading piece of music, a yellowing piece of music, and just like you described with the flycrap. And so I'm just playing it. And you know I'll read anything. And I'm playing it, but you don't have the feeling. You've got to be born to that kind of music like I'm born to play jazz. But I'm reading and I'm reading. And we're going on. And so fine, we get to the show, so again, they put the piano out in the center. Now she comes out and she's got these wonderful parts, what a wonderful singer. And we're playing and we're playing and playing. And Doc is turning pages for me. So Doc got nervous, and he turned several pages at once, and there I am trying to fake some aria which I have no idea what it's about. And you can't really fake that stuff. I mean it sounds like free jazz. And this lady is singing her heart out. But anyway, somehow we got back on track but then I noticed after that that the lady brought in her own accompanist the next time she came in.

MW: That must have been, that must have been a blast. Tell me some of the other interesting people that you accompanied when you played on the show.

DS: Well—

MW: Some of the most fun people you backed up.

DS: Well, lots of people. It wasn't on that particular show, I'm trying to think of that particular show, but really the funniest story was it wasn't the Tonight Show, but it was at the same time. I came home from work and I think it was after Benny and there was a message from our service, we all belonged to this service it was called. And my wife had said that the Registry called, you've got to be at ABC Television at 5:30 it's the Good Morning America show, you know, it's a network show, you've got to accompany Pavarotti. And that was the end of the message. So it was already one o'clock, you know.

MR: This is AM?

DS: Yes, so I said it's too late now to start getting the opera books out and start practicing, so I just got up early and go into town, at least there's no traffic going to town I'm already there. So I'm there for the 5:30 rehearsal, the show goes on at 7 AM, you know. And so I'm getting a little antsy. I said well at least we should run down this stuff, you know. So I'm looking at my watch, 6:00 comes and no Pavarotti, 6:15, and I'm starting to get a little nervous. And so at quarter to 7, I was supposed to go on at 7, the door opens, and in comes this great big guy, you know, this presence. And he makes, goes to the lady producer and starts putting his arms around her and is making out with the lady producer, and I'm running around saying, "where's the music?" And I finally get his attention, it's 5 to 7 now. Funny. And I said, "I'm the pianist, which aria are you going to sing? You know, give me a shot, we've got to rehearse it." "Oh," he says, "see my manager." I says, "where's the manager?" So he says, "that little guy in the corner." So I find the little guy

in the corner, he's got this briefcase. I said, "I'm the pianist for Mr. Pavarotti. Which aria is he going to sing?" So the guy opens the thing, and he gets me out this old piece of music, I look at and it says "We Wish You A Merry Christmas."

MR: Oh, man —

DS: Well I played the hell out of it. And I listed that on my resume — played with Pavarotti. But I mean all those guys over the years, I played with everybody — Frank Sinatra. Frank was between conductors and he's had a pianist with him, a guy called Bill Miller, forever. They're buddies all their lives. Well, he didn't like the conductor so they elevated Bill Miller to be the conductor, and they said well we need a pianist, so get Derek in for this weekend. So I came down to Atlantic City to play, and so Frank is kind of older now, and he takes time in between things. And I'm kind of nervous see, I don't trust the conductor and I'm thinking who am I going to get my cues from? But anyway, the tune comes up and it's a piano arpeggio or something. So I give him the arpeggio. Frank stops, and he comes over to the piano and he's got a drink, and he takes a drink, and he starts telling a story to the audience. It's funny, and he has a drink and it's the last show. And so he stops. So I give him the arpeggio again, you know. He comes back to the piano and takes another drink and he tells another story. And I'm really getting uptight here. So I give him another arpeggio. And he turns around to me and he deliberately says, "it's okay, kid, you don't have to hit me with a truck." I said okay, I didn't know what he had got. But in that time I worked with all these guys — Placido Domingo, they all came in and you just read the music. And I remember Placido, with a big orchestra, and you know he's got a wonderful set of pipes and a marvelous voice. He says "don't like that, take you up a minor third." And this big orchestra. And nobody batted an eyelid. Everybody went straight into it and I have the piano part, I go woops!

MR: No kidding. You mean the orchestra transposed it?

DS: Absolutely. And not a word was said. Nobody complained — boom — straight into it.

MR: I have never heard of that.

DS: Oh, yeah.

MR: That's not usually a skill that most people have.

MW: That happened to us one time at Indiana University. We were playing a piece, the conductor said, "not exciting enough." He said, "transpose up a minor third." And he said, "next rehearsal, one of two things. If you can do it by ear, do it. If you can't I want it written out on your own part. But when I call that modulation, it better be there."

DS: Well, you know, it's another skill. I used to get upset if singers would say that. Singers would come in with some sheet and say, "I do it in A" or "G flat" and you know, and I'd get real smart and say, "well I don't." But depending on how much respect you had for

them. If it was some singer that I, you know, say oh she couldn't tell the difference between the G flat and G, so I'm going to play it in the key that seems right for me.

MR: Yeah, it's in your key now, right?

DS: But some of them know, and they'll get my respect, and I'll work with them.

MR: Yeah. Working with singers can be very interesting.

MW: You know they tell this joke they say, how do you know when there's a singer on your front porch?

DS: If it's not their key—

MW: If it's not her key they don't know where to come in. Let me ask you this question. How do you feel that jazz is a representation of oral culture?

DS: I have no idea.

MW: As compared to literate culture. I mean some of it's on the page, but by all means not all of it's not on the page.

DS: I don't know what you're asking me. I can't translate that into terms I can understand.

MW: Oral culture is just information or education passed on sonically where you learn by sound, rather than by learning by literate culture through the page.

DS: Well, if you're really asking me whether jazz is a triumph of education over talent, no there's no question about it. I think that the finest players are the guys who feel it here, and it comes out, and I'll take a guy who really cannot play the instrument too well, but I recognize the signs of music coming out there, and it's just a question before he can really do it better. I mean it would be embarrassing, I could name you names of people I've heard at early stages of development, and people say, "ah, the guy can't play." And I say, "listen, can't you hear what he's trying to play? He's hearing it in his head, he just doesn't know enough about the instrument yet to play it properly. Come back in a year or so." I can think of certain guys who are wonderful now. And I don't know whether that really answers your question.

MR: Well you learned mostly from records.

DS: Right, sure. I started learning from records. Then I think I learned mostly from playing with other guys. People do things when you're playing. And it changes all your ideas. And that's what I love about jazz, and you know I'm developing a solo act now simply because that's the way it is, but I love that playing with all the guys, because just, whatever they feel about a song, or whatever you're playing, it makes you play differently with their input. Because you all play off of each other.

MR: What about working with Milt Hinton?

DS: Milt's the greatest. You know, I mean we all love him, he's going to be 85, but we're also worried because when Milt goes, a sizable amount of this music goes, you know, a whole way of playing – a whole way of playing. There's nobody else does that like that. So we

all guard him very dearly. It's a whole feeling. It's like the previous question, you can't really write down what that feeling means. It's, you just have to be there and be around the man and play, and feel the enthusiasm and how gets from one place to another. And I've tried to analyze it and find it very difficult.

MW: You know there is an authenticity that is at the heart of the best jazz music that I've heard or participated in. And something that alarms me is that in some of today's pop music I feel like they're playing chords or they're singing lyrics just to sell an album and I don't feel sometimes that the musicians have experienced what it is that they're saying or playing. You know? And do you see any young artists today that are bringing any of that authenticity back?

DS: Well, that's hard for me to say. I must admit I've been as guilty as others my age that I've really turned away from that music because I don't find anything that reflects my ideas. But you know, my children respect me for what I do, but they've got their own kind of music, and it's today's music. I can't really answer your question. There are young players who play jazz, I mean I see them all the time. But I think their roots are in the music that we played, and so they're carrying on and developing that tradition. Some of the newer music I find difficult to listen to. When it comes to pop music, I've often gone into this argument and say well pop music now is so terrible. But pop music has always been exactly that. It's been the popular music of the age. I don't think jazz was ever the popular music of the age. It was always a minority interest. And so we get together and have these discussions about it and put down rap music, but you know there was so much in the '20's and '30's of moon and June and spoon, and really dumb things, and we just accepted it because we were young then. But it's no better or worse, it's just the popular music of the time. I don't think jazz was ever the popular music of the time. I mean maybe swing in the '40's I suppose—

MR: Yeah, that was more of a dance — there wasn't nearly as much improvisation — it was more arranged.

DS: Exactly.

MW: Have you had occasion to perform with Joe Williams?

DS: Well, on the same stage. I haven't—because he's usually had Norman Simmons playing for him, even if I'm the studio pianist in the orchestra, you know, he's got his own piano player. But I've known Joe all these years, and always been a fan of his.

MW: How do you feel his voice is, typifies jazz vocals?

DS: Well, he sounds to me like a good tenor player playing. It's something in the timbre of his voice. It's, I don't know how to describe that either, but it's something in the timbre. You know there's an art to singing or playing a melody. It sort of becomes, not just acceptable but brilliant. And Joe's got that, effortlessly. And really he's not playing hot

like Frank Wess is playing hot, but you know if you hear Frank playing the melody, and it's beautiful. And Joe is playing around the melody.

MR: Yeah, we heard that last night, actually, one of his ballads.

DS: Yeah, Joe's got it.

MR: Do you have any quick words about what it's like to play in other countries and how they accept our, you know—

DS: It's interesting. I've been to Japan a fair amount, and they're so serious about the music. I guess that's the Japanese, it's a very authoritarian, a very patriarchal society. I don't know whether that explains it or not. But I remember playing, I was over there with a bunch of guys led by Benny Carter, and this was 1985, and we were sitting around like this after a concert, and a guy comes in with a shopping bag. And he doesn't go to all these other guys who were much better known that I was. But he comes to me and he says in halting English, "I have every record you ever made." I said, "what?" And he proceeded to put them out on the table and he just wanted me to sign them. And I was so flattered. You know he'd got records there that I didn't know were out on the market, and some I've certainly never been paid for. But this man had everything. And he knew dates, and who was on everything. I'm just using this to demonstrate how much they're into the music and the musicians. I guess you call them "musicographers" perhaps more than players, there are a few good Japanese players, but they're so interested in jazz as a subject. And if you go to Europe it always upsets me because you can go to this place, they call it "The Zoo" but it's the North Sea Festival and it's in Hague, and it's the biggest one that I know. You can go into this huge building and there are twelve stages going constantly for about ten hours a day, and maybe more than that, with all different attractions. And it's mobbed. That's what upsets me. I seldom go to a festival in this country where there are that many people running around. And naturally on this ship it's full of older people who like kind of older mainstream music. But if you go to Europe and you go to Japan, huge crowds of younger people interested in jazz. I think that's about it.

MR: Well do you have any last words for our young jazz people at school, or Mike do you have something?

MW: Yeah. I wanted to just ask you if you could give a word to young people, college age people, that you know are going to see this interview in years to come. If you could give them just a piece of advice about listening to and participating in or appreciating this music. Any hints? Any insights that would help them get handles on it, quickly and easily?

DS: Well of course it's different than when I was a kid. There weren't all these music programs at colleges for one thing. When I grew up there was two colleges, Oxford and

Cambridge. And you had to be brilliant to get into there. And they certainly didn't have a jazz program. But now you can go to college — almost any major college now has got a jazz program. I'm sure they vary, some are better than others. But there are some that are really very good. And so a kid with talent, if they can possibly afford to get there on a scholarship or something, should go to one of these and soak up as much information as they can. But like we were talking about before, it's not really the information it's the talent and managing to bring it out. Now my own experience has been you can only do that by playing with players. I always try and make it a point, always try to play with people who are better than you, because that's the way you're going to learn. And not just playing, but hanging around, talking to them. There's so much to talk about, especially the older players, you know somebody like Milt to talk to. I mean Milt's the greatest guy in an airplane on a long plane ride, because he's got so many stories. Some are funny, some are cogent, some are—that's great for young people to hear. I don't think there are any shortcuts. You've got to keep playing your instrument, keep learning. I always tell them, you know, for business reasons, learn to write, learn to sing, learn all the angles of the business, which I didn't learn until I was much older. Learn about publishing. You know publishers make all the money.

MW: Sometimes the artist is the last one to see his money am I right?

DS: Absolutely. We create it but it's a business. And learn that it's a business. I think kids know that today. They're much hipper about it. But I kind of regret that I was much older before I found out things like that, I wasn't into it. I just wanted to play, I wanted to play. And I can't play this thing that I hear in my head, I've got to keep playing. But I don't think there are any shortcuts. I don't know whether that was Clark Terry's words but he says first you imitate, then you assimilate, and lastly then you [innovate]. It's wonderful really and I don't find any shortcuts. Just keep playing and try to play with people that are better than you all the time.

MR: All right. We want to thank Derek Smith for joining us on this wonderful cruise, and say goodbye now for the Hamilton Jazz Archive.

DS: Over and out.